

“Rainbow Nation”). A country whose state boundaries correspond to those of a particular nation is described as a nation-state.

The precise origins of nationalism are unclear. One idea, called primordialism, is that nations are simply the outward territorial expression of the divisions between people of different ethnicity or culture. This idea of “cultural

nationalism” was first expressed by the 18th-century German philosopher Johann Gottfried von Herder. He believed that nature had separated nations by “languages, inclinations, and characters.” Opposition to this idea states that the concept of nationalism came first, followed by the artificial creation of nations, for political or economic reasons. In the 20th century,

Czech-born British social philosopher Ernest Gellner said: “Nationalism is not the awakening of nations... it invents nations where they do not exist.” More recently, it has been proposed that national identities evolve by merging with new ethnic and cultural influences.

Today the idea of the nation-state is well established, but that was not always the case. Until the medieval

period, most people’s loyalties were specific: to their tribe, religious leader, or feudal landlord. As people developed a sense of nationhood (see BEFORE) they began to demand the right to self-government. In America and France the liberal ideals of freedom, equality, and brotherhood (fraternity) led to nation-states that granted their citizens unchallengeable rights and were governed in the name of the people.

Consequences of nationalism

Once nation-statehood had been achieved, some less savory aspects of nationalism emerged. Napoleon tried to impose the French identity on much of Europe (see pp.304–07), and the belief that the United States had a “manifest destiny” (see pp.310–11) to take over North America came at the expense of the native population. The idea that the nation-state should cherish itself above all others could lead to racism, religious intolerance, and imperialism. The British politician Cecil Rhodes said, “If there is a God, then He would like to see me... color as much of the map of Africa British red as possible.” Britain’s imperialism went on to encourage nationalist movements

AFTER

Throughout the 20th century, nationalism showed its two faces, freeing some while subjugating others.

FANATICISM AND FASCISM

In 1814, the French foreign minister **Charles-Maurice de Talleyrand-Périgord** wrote of those people wishing to reunite the German Empire: “The unity of the German Fatherland is their slogan, their faith, and their religion. They are **ardent to the point of fanaticism**... Who can say where a movement of that kind might stop?” Over a century later, **Adolf Hitler 390–91** took advantage of a similarly strong nationalist sentiment in Germany to seize power, culminating in World War II **392–405**.

FREEDOM

Nationalist movements brought independence to former European colonies throughout Africa and Asia, such as Egypt, Indonesia, and Algeria **412–13**.

REACHING EXTREMES

Nationalism was also the root of civil war and genocide in, for example, the former Yugoslavia **450–51**, and the terrorist activities of **nationalist groups** such as the IRA in Northern Ireland **436–37** and ETA in Spain.



NAZI PROPAGANDA

